

Reconciliation



A wall has been broken open. Rubble on both sides, light pouring through the gap. Peace here is not a feeling that the wall was never real. The wall came down.

Before you gather

- Read Day 18, Reconciliation, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Ephesians 2:13–18 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.

- Leave with a name. The missional challenge only works if someone is named before you pray.

1 · ICEBREAKER · 7 MIN

Open the room

What small wall do people build without noticing — a closed door, a seat saved, a silence?

Leader. Name a real distance. Then open Ephesians 2. The wall that mattered was between us and God, and between peoples. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 · THE WORD · 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: Reconciliation means God ended the war our sin started. The blood of the cross brought enemies near. We do not make peace on our own.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Reconciliation is God ending the war and separation our sin created by the blood of His Son, Jesus Christ, and granting us lasting peace with Himself.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek *katallagē* — a change from enmity to friendship. Also *eirēnē* — peace.

MEMORY VERSE · COLOSSIANS 1:19–20

For in him all the fullness of God was pleased to dwell, and through him to reconcile to himself all things, whether on earth or in heaven, making peace by the blood of his cross.

Together, open the flashcard for Reconciliation. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

3 · OPEN THE BIBLE · 15 MIN

Ephesians 2:13–18

Colossians 1:19–20 is the memory verse. Stay in Ephesians 2:13–18. Far off, brought near by the blood of Christ. Do not start with relationship advice.

But now in Christ Jesus you who once were far off have been brought near by the blood of Christ. For he himself is our peace, who has made us both one and has broken down in his flesh the dividing wall of hostility by abolishing the law of commandments expressed in ordinances, that he might create in himself one new man in place of the two, so making peace, and might reconcile us both to God in one body through the cross, thereby killing the hostility. And he came and preached peace to you who were far off and peace to those who were near.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. Ephesians 2:13. What were we, and what brought us near? CORE

Leader. We were far off. The blood of Christ brought us near. Not our effort to be nicer. The blood.

2. Verse 14 says He is our peace, who broke down the dividing wall. Who made the peace?

Leader. Christ. He made one new man. He reconciled both to God in one body through the cross. Peace is a Person and a death, not a mood.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. Romans 5:10 says while we were enemies we were reconciled by the death of His Son. What were we before the cross did its work?

Leader. Enemies, not basically good people having a rough patch. Say the word enemies. Then say the death of the Son.

4. If two people in town will not speak, how is the gospel more than “you should apologize”? CORE

Leader. God made peace with enemies through the blood of His Son. We forgive and move toward people because He moved toward us. Apology without Christ is not the gospel.

5. 2 Corinthians 5:18–20 says God reconciled us and gave us the ministry of reconciliation. What are we supposed to say?

Leader. Be reconciled to God. We are ambassadors. The message is about God, not only about two neighbors getting along.

5 · SAY IT · 5 MIN

In one sentence

Reconciliation means God ended the war our sin started, through the blood of the cross, and brought us near.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 · THIS WEEK · 5 MIN

Missional challenge

Before next week, carry this word to someone far from Jesus — a neighbor, a classmate, a coworker, a friend. Do it with a real action and with a true sentence. Name the person before you pray.

Take one step toward a person you are distant from who does not follow Jesus. If you owe an apology, give it. Tell them God makes peace with enemies through the blood of His Son.

Leader. If the other person is unsafe, tell the truth from a distance. Do not force a reunion. The sentence is about being reconciled to God. Next week, before the icebreaker, take one minute. Who went, and what happened? One sentence. No speeches.

7 · PRAY · 8 MIN

Pray these, and leave room for others

1. Father, we were far off, and You brought us near by the blood of Christ.
2. Forgive us for keeping wars You have told us to end.
3. Make us ambassadors this week. Open one mouth to say, "Be reconciled to God."

Before you stumble

Do not turn this into relationship advice with Jesus as an illustration. The wall in the text is hostility toward God, and hostility between peoples, broken at the cross. Horizontal peace comes from vertical peace. If someone wants only the horizontal, bring them back to verse 16.

WITH STUDENTS

Ask who at school is "far off" from them. Then read verse 13. Christ brings the far off near by His blood. Ask who they will move toward.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Colossians 1:21–22. You were alienated and hostile. He has now reconciled you in His body of flesh by His death. Read it and give thanks.